

MASTERCLASS STUDY COMPANION

COMBO PROSPECTING

The Powerful One-Two Punch That Fills Your Pipeline and Wins Sales

THE ONE-TWO PUNCH

with Tony J. Hughes

The Social Phone

Tony Hughes frames prospecting as a fight. Your left hand is social and digital outreach; your right hand is the phone. Blended together they become the “social phone”—the one-two punch at the heart of COMBO Prospecting. (COMBO is both the combination itself and an acronym: Command Over Maximizing Business Opportunities.) Neither hand wins alone. This companion follows the book’s arc across three movements: first you get in the fight and fix your mindset; then you earn the right to an executive’s time and build the platform that carries you; finally you throw the combo in a disciplined cadence and lead yourself like a professional.

MOVEMENT I Get in the Fight

Mindset — wake up, face the truth, refuse the false choice

MOVEMENT II Earn the Right & Build Your Platform

The jab — relevance, trust, insight, and the base you fight from

MOVEMENT III Throw the Combo & Lead Yourself

The knockout — execution, breakthrough, and personal leadership

MOVEMENT I

Get in the Fight

Mindset — wake up, face the truth, refuse the false choice

“If you set yourself on fire, the world will come to see you burn.”

— Don King

KEY STORIES

- Hughes opens by telling you to make your hands into fists: the left is social, the right is the phone. Blended, they become the “social phone”—a term he credits to Kenny Madden.
- COMBO is both the combination of channels and an acronym: Command Over Maximizing Business Opportunities.
- The Pareto principle rules prospecting: 20 percent of the right input drives 80 percent of the outcome—yet most sellers waste 80 percent of their time.
- He thanks Steve Jobs for building the first genuinely mobile COMBO tool, then warns that “an amateur with expensive tools is still ineffective.”

THE CORE LESSON

Neither social nor phone works alone. The win comes from intelligently combining digital jabs—LinkedIn, email, text, Twitter—that set up the knockout phone call.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Treat social and phone as one weapon, not two separate channels—jab digitally to set up the phone.
 2. The prospect is not the enemy; the enemy is the apathy, walls, and resistance surrounding them.
 3. Commit to massive, consistent action—get in the ring every single day.
 4. Read what the pros read. CEOs read dozens of books a year; most salespeople read none.
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“Everybody has a plan until they get punched in the mouth.”

— Iron Mike Tyson

KEY STORIES

- A LinkedIn troll once demanded, “Who are you...really? No one can come from nowhere and know all this!” Hughes notes it took him 35 years to become an “overnight success.”
- The honey badger: Australian rugby star Nick Cummins earned the nickname for fearless, full-throttle play—“tough as woodpecker lips.” The honey badger fears nothing and never gets fired.
- Grant Cardone’s 10X: go harder, deeper, and wider into your accounts. As Cardone says, “We sell to survive!”
- Pressure over time creates diamonds—you either implode or you become stronger.

THE CORE LESSON

The awful truth is that sellers have become passive, quiet, fearful, and lazy. Success demands you wake up, get in the fight, and out-work your competition.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Face the facts about your own numbers—facts don’t lie.
 2. Be the honey badger: fearless, relentless, and never fired because you always feed the pipeline.
 3. Hit 10X activity—go harder, deeper, and wider into your target accounts.
 4. Expect to get punched in the mouth. Resilience is the job, not a bonus.
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“Social and digital alone fail. Phone alone fails. Intelligent combinations are the only way to win.”

— Tony J. Hughes

KEY STORIES

- The “cyborg seller” in the age of the machines fuses human engagement with technology rather than choosing one over the other.
- The cold-calling-versus-social-selling debate is itself the trap—Hughes calls the either/or framing lunacy.
- The phone alone reaches maybe two or three prospects out of a hundred; social alone is passive attraction that fails.
- The savviest social sellers still call like crazy.

THE CORE LESSON

The future belongs to the cyborg seller who fuses old-school phone grit with modern social tools—refusing the false choice between them.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Reject the cold-call-versus-social debate; do both, together.
 2. Use technology to be human at scale, not to hide behind a screen.
 3. Social selling without the phone is just passive attraction—and it fails.
 4. Blend old and new. The combination is rare, which is exactly why it wins.
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MOVEMENT II

Earn the Right & Build Your Platform

The job — relevance, trust, insight, and the base you fight from

"I fear not the man who has practiced 10,000 kicks once, but I fear the man who has practiced one kick 10,000 times."

— Bruce Lee

KEY STORIES

- The bluebird commission story: Hughes won one of the biggest deals in his company's history, then his boss tried to claw back the commission by invoking an "out-of-the-ordinary bluebird" clause—a raw test of values.
- "Are you really the person worthy of the success you seek?" Most people in leadership secretly worry about being found out.
- Foundations of executive engagement start with speaking the language of leaders—business outcomes, not product features.

THE CORE LESSON

You earn the right to an executive's time by being relevant to their world and their language—never by pitching your products.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Speak the language of leaders: business outcomes, risk, and results—not features.
 2. Relevance is the price of admission to any executive conversation.
 3. Your values show under pressure. Be the real deal, not a suit of confidence.
 4. Master one thing deeply—10,000 kicks—rather than dabbling in many.
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“The successful warrior approaches with genuine curiosity, not hunger.”

— On the Paradox of Nonhunger

KEY STORIES

- The paradox of nonhunger: the less you appear to need the deal, the more attractive you become to the buyer.
- Friending is not relationship selling—don’t confuse a pile of LinkedIn connections with real trust.
- The power of truly listening: most sellers listen to respond, not to understand.

THE CORE LESSON

Trust and value are built through genuine curiosity and real listening. Desperation repels; curiosity attracts.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Lead with curiosity, not commission breath.
 2. Don’t confuse “friending” on social with a real relationship.
 3. Listen to understand, not to reload your pitch.
 4. The paradox of nonhunger: detachment from the outcome makes you more compelling.
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“Opening is the new closing!”

— Anthony Iannarino

KEY STORIES

- Lead with insight that reframes how the prospect sees their own business—the Challenger move.
- Hughes points to the strategic-selling canon: Solution Selling, SPIN Selling, Miller Heiman, New Power Base Selling, Diagnostic Business Development, and The Challenger Sale.
- Build your own value narrative and ask questions that qualify and set the agenda.
- Winning requires building a business case and engineering consensus before the meeting, not after.

THE CORE LESSON

You earn the meeting by leading with a relevant insight and a value narrative that reframes the prospect’s thinking. Opening is the new closing.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Do pragmatic research—Google News, direct quotes, trigger events—before any outreach.
 2. Lead with insight that challenges their status quo.
 3. Build a value narrative about them, not about your company.
 4. Ask questions that qualify and set the agenda; engineer consensus early.
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"I hated every minute of training, but I said, 'Don't quit. Suffer now and live the rest of your life as a champion.'"

— Muhammad Ali

KEY STORIES

- The cyclist “bonking” analogy: no athlete wins without first building a base of fitness—and no seller wins without first building a platform.
- Create an online brand and publish insights that set the agenda for your market.
- Nurture a network—the strength of weak ties, a lesson Hughes credits to Reid Hoffman and Jeff Weiner.
- Invest in the tools of the trade: LinkedIn Sales Navigator, plus sales intelligence like DiscoverOrg or ZoomInfo. Then run Account-Based Everything.

THE CORE LESSON

Sustained prospecting rests on a platform: a credible brand, a nurtured network, sharp tools, and published insight—built through quiet discipline before the spotlight arrives.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Build your brand and platform before you need it, like an athlete's base fitness.
 2. Publish insight that sets the agenda and attracts the right buyers.
 3. Nurture your network; weak ties open the most unexpected doors.
 4. Buy the tools of the trade—Sales Navigator and sales intelligence—even if your boss won't.
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MOVEMENT III

Throw the Combo & Lead Yourself

The knockout — execution, breakthrough, and personal leadership

“To hell with circumstances, I create opportunities. The successful warrior is the average man, with laser-like focus.”

— Bruce Lee

KEY STORIES

- Be your own Sales Development Rep—don’t outsource your pipeline. Hughes points to Predictable Revenue by Aaron Ross and Marylou Tyler, the Salesforce scaling case study.
- Shocking paradoxes govern prospecting: the activities that feel least urgent are the ones that decide next quarter.
- Time-blocking is discipline within the hours—protected prospecting time, defended without excuse.
- Watch for trigger events and listen socially for the opening.

THE CORE LESSON

Own your pipeline like an SDR and protect prospecting time with ruthless time-blocking. Opportunities are created, not waited for.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Be your own SDR; never fully outsource pipeline creation.
 2. Time-block prospecting daily and defend it without excuse.
 3. Watch for trigger events and listen socially for the moment to strike.
 4. Create opportunities with laser focus—don’t wait for circumstances.
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“A referral is the fastest path to revenue.”

— Tony J. Hughes

KEY STORIES

- A warm referral is the fastest path to revenue and the highest probability of a sale—so always deliver for your clients and build a high-quality network.
- Multi-threading means generating multiple communication avenues to multiple stakeholders and setting meetings in parallel.
- The Challenger Customer argues that challenging the many fiefdoms is what builds real consensus.
- The advanced playbook and insider secrets all point the same way: never depend on a single champion.

THE CORE LESSON

The highest-probability path is a warm referral, and complex deals are won by multi-threading across many stakeholders—not by leaning on one contact.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Ask for referrals—the fastest, highest-probability path to revenue.
 2. Deliver relentlessly for existing clients so referrals flow naturally.
 3. Multi-thread: reach multiple stakeholders in parallel.
 4. Engineer consensus across fiefdoms rather than relying on one person.
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“Never use ‘checking in’ or ‘touching base.’ Never remind them of your failed past attempts.”

— Tony J. Hughes

KEY STORIES

- COMBOs to conquer executive ADD: cut through the noise with relevance and brevity.
- Breaking through to CXOs and board members requires you to sound like a peer, not a vendor.
- The anatomy of giving good social phone: voicemail and digital touches working together, never alone.
- Growth hacks and even “ghosting” your own CEO’s profile can open doors at the top.

THE CORE LESSON

Executives have ADD from the noise. Break through with relevance, brevity, and a confident social-phone combo—and never sound like a low-level seller.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Kill the weak phrases: “checking in,” “touching base,” “just 15 minutes.”
 2. Lead every executive touch with relevance and insight.
 3. Give good social phone—voicemail plus digital, always working together.
 4. Use growth hacks and CEO ghosting to open doors at the top.
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“Dispelling the myths of the serial closer.”

— Tony J. Hughes

KEY STORIES

- Supercharge lead flow by pulling every tactic together into one repeatable machine.
- Turn up the heat deeper in the funnel, not just at the top.
- Dispelling the myths of the serial closer: closing is the natural result of a good process, not a manipulative trick.

THE CORE LESSON

When the whole system runs together, lead flow compounds—and “closing” becomes the natural outcome of relevance and process, not a trick.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Pull every tactic together into one repeatable lead-flow machine.
 2. Keep the heat on deeper in the funnel, not only at the top.
 3. Forget closing tricks—closing is the byproduct of a good process.
 4. Measure and refine the machine relentlessly.
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Avoid the Roller-Coaster, Live the 80/20, Become a Mentor

“The world is full of people who want to play it safe—people who could do more, be more, and have more, if only they were willing to take a few risks.”

— George Foreman

KEY STORIES

- The hard truth: “You are the very reason you don’t have the success you think you deserve.” Stop blaming the boss, the market, or bad luck.
- The IBM deal: Hughes sold at 70 percent higher prices than the incumbent—who had a bigger brand and network—by prospecting relentlessly and without excuse, avoiding the roller-coaster.
- Think like a Marine: it’s a privilege to serve, no matter how much is thrown your way.
- 80/20 power laws govern personal effectiveness—and the best sellers become mentors and coaches.

THE CORE LESSON

Elite prospecting is an act of personal leadership: own your results, prospect every day to kill the roller-coaster, live by the 80/20, and lift others as a mentor.

TAKEAWAYS

1. Own your results completely—stop blaming circumstances.
 2. Prospect every day to escape the pipeline roller-coaster.
 3. Apply 80/20 to focus on the vital few activities and accounts.
 4. Become a mentor—leadership is lifting others, not just yourself.
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The Action Guide

The wisdom of COMBO Prospecting reorganized into a three-phase campaign you can run: **BUILD** the platform, **ATTACK** with the one-two punch, and **SUSTAIN** the fight through personal leadership.

BUILD

Lay the platform before the fight

- **Set up your tool stack**

Get LinkedIn Sales Navigator and a sales-intelligence source (DiscoverOrg, ZoomInfo, or similar). Buy them yourself if you have to—they are the Bloomberg terminal of modern selling.

- **Rebuild your profile as a buyer-facing brand**

Rewrite your LinkedIn presence to signal credibility, curiosity, and aligned values. It should speak to your buyer, not read like a resume.

- **Publish insight that sets the agenda**

Post and share content that reframes how your market thinks. Become a voice worth following before you ask for anything.

- **Build and segment your target list**

Define your territory, market fit, and the specific accounts worth 10X effort. Precision beats volume.

- **Nurture your network**

Work your weak ties, alumni, and past colleagues. The strength of weak ties opens the most doors.

- **Craft your value narrative**

Write the insight hooks and business-case story you will lead with—about the buyer's world, not your product.

ATTACK

Throw the one-two punch every day

- **Time-block prospecting and defend it**

Reserve protected hours daily and guard them without excuse. This is how you avoid the roller-coaster.

- **Research before you reach out**

Run a Google News search, capture a real quote, and find a trigger event you can reference.

- **Run the COMBO**

Jab with digital—LinkedIn, email, text—to set up the phone knockout. Never rely on one hand alone.

- **Multi-thread the account**

Open parallel conversations with multiple stakeholders instead of betting on one champion.

- **Ask for referrals**

Pursue warm introductions—the fastest, highest-probability path to revenue.

- **Break executive ADD with relevance**

Kill “checking in” and “touching base.” Lead with insight and brevity, and sound like a peer.

- **Give good social phone**

Pair voicemail with digital touches so each reinforces the other.

SUSTAIN

Lead yourself like a professional

- **Prospect every single day**

Consistency beats intensity. Daily prospecting is the only cure for the pipeline roller-coaster.

- **Track your numbers honestly**

Face the facts about your activity and conversion. Facts don't lie.

- **Apply the 80/20 rule**

Concentrate on the vital few accounts and activities that drive most of the result.

- **Read what the pros read**

Work through the books and blogs Hughes cites. CEOs read dozens a year; be the seller who does too.

- **Be the honey badger**

Stay fearless and relentless. The seller who always feeds the pipeline never gets fired.

- **Become a mentor and coach**

Lift the people around you. Personal leadership is measured by who you develop, not just what you close.

QUICK REFERENCE

Twelve Principles

One principle per lesson. Print it, pin it, fight from it.

- 01** The left is social, the right is the phone—throw both.
- 02** Wake up and get in the fight; be the honey badger.
- 03** Reject the either/or—be a cyborg seller.
- 04** Earn the right by speaking the language of leaders.
- 05** Curiosity attracts; desperation repels.
- 06** Opening is the new closing—lead with insight.
- 07** Build the platform before you need it.
- 08** Be your own SDR; time-block and defend it.
- 09** Referrals are the fastest path; multi-thread the rest.
- 10** Break executive ADD with relevance—kill ‘just checking in.’
- 11** Closing is the byproduct of a good process.
- 12** Own your results; prospect daily; mentor others.

“The left is social, the right is the phone. Blended together, they are the social phone.”

— Tony J. Hughes, COMBO Prospecting